Collective-Political Creativity Around the World: A Relay Interview

Katherine Mollenhauer Gajardo
Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile
kamollenhauer@uc.cl
ORCID 0000-0002-6817-5013

Raffaele Laudani
Alma Mater Studiorum
— Università di Bologna
raffaele.laudani@unibo.it
ORCID 0000-0002-0327-4301

Ambra Trotto
Umeå Institute of Design
and RISE Research Institutes of Sweden
ambra.trotto@ri.se
ORCID 0000-0002-8733-2272

Gabriella Gómez-Mont
Experimentalista
gabriella@experimentalistas.com

Giovanni Ginocchini
Comune di Bologna
giovanni.ginocchini@comune.bologna.it
ORCID 0000-0003-3093-7390

Abstract
The five authors of the relay interview, through their contribution, stimulate a comprehensive reflection on the issue of collective and political creativity from the situational specificities of four different contexts.
From the dialogue, a profoundly evolving scenario emerges in which collective creativity, multidimensional co-design and inclusion are key to sustainable action.

Keywords
Sustainability
Creative participation
Interdisciplinary approach
Ecosystem design
Communities

Copyright © 2022
diid disegno industriale
industrial design
CC BY-NC-SA

Introduction

As Editors of the section Open Debate, we imagined that the theme of collective and political creativity could not be declined in this issue of diid as a single point of view, but could be approached from different geographical and thought coordinates.

The decision was made to stimulate the invited authors to take part in the discussion by means of a relay interview, through which to stimulate a global reflection from the situational specificities in four different contexts and through equally different profiles of the contributors. Katherin Mollenhauer from the Research Center on Governance and Territorial Planning in Chile, Gabriella Gómez-Mont founder of Experimentalista in Mexico, Giovanni Ginocchini and Raffaele Laudani founders of Foundation of Urban Innovation in Italy and now representatives of the Municipality of Bologna, Ambra Trotto of the Research Center of Sweden, have accepted our invitation, telling us about their experience and stimulating a discussion that remains open and multi-domain.

What emerges is a complex and profoundly evolving scenario in which creativity with citizens and politicians, co-design in decision-making processes, inclusion and diversity are critical to shaping "a sustainable way of being and acting in the world".

Katherine Mollenhauer Gajardo — Chile

My name is Katherine Mollenhauer Gajardo, Doctor in Strategic Design and Innovation and professor at the design school of the Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile and a member of the Research Center on Governance and Territorial Planning (NuGOT) of the Institute of Urban Studies of the same university. In this interdisciplinary space, I contribute, from Systemic Design (SD) and Systems Oriented Design (SOD) (Ryan, 2013, 2014; Sevaldson 2016, 2019) to the research and development of co-creation models and methodologies (Sanders & Stappers, 2008; Sanders & Simons, 2009; LIP, 2017) that allow creative and binding participation of the inhabitants in the decision-making processes for the design of Territorial Planning Instruments (TPI) (Pujada & Font, 1998).

From our perspective, the territory — whether urban, rural, or mixed — and its population are diverse. From the SD and SOD, this diversity is expressed not only in different socioeconomic situations, locations, work and personal relationships, natural and built environments but also and above all, in the backgrounds, experiences, perceptions, expectations, and interactions of people that inhabit it (Mulgan, 2014). This entails complexity because it not only considers the individual as something isolated in the territory but also the relationships that this individual has with other agents, forming an ecosystem (Pinazo-Dallenbach & Tutistar-Rosero, 2020). Then, it is vital that when a decision-making process is approached for the TPI design, the ecosystem's actors — inhabitants of the territory, local government, ministry functionaries from the central government, and the research team — manage to share the diagnosis and the prospective (Godet, 2007).

diid No. 77 — 2022
Doi: 10.30682/diid7722e

For the researchers, the challenge is to address the complexity of a co-creation process (LIP, 2017) where multiple areas of knowledge and disciplines (Pinazo-Dallenbach & Tutistar-Rosero, 2020) appear since a system of systems is formed.

From this perspective, how to address this diversity from an interdisciplinary approach (Sevaldson & Jones, 2019) to better understand and align the needs, desires, and expectations of its inhabitants and territories (CoLab, 2016)? And how can co-creation (Aguirre, 2020), in the ecosystem facilitate or not the convergence of people's expectations (Manzini, 2009) in the generation of initiatives for a better quality of life for its inhabitants and care for the territory (Orellana, Arenas & Moreno, 2020)?

Gabriella Gómez-Mont — Mexico

My name is Gabriella Gómez-Mont and I am Founder and CEO of Experimentalista. In a purely technocratic view of the city, the way we mostly make sense of urban life is by quantifying our cities and societies, labeling everything with numbers and redrawing the urbanscape onto an excel sheet. "What cannot be counted cannot be addressed", says one telling maxim. And this is true to a certain extent. Data driven policy has proven to be an important tool in addressing urban challenges. However, this numbered and quantified city, often, with time, leaves little space for understanding other deep forces that drive cities and collective life — and hence we often ignore that other city that is too alive, too restless, too unbound and changing and even messy; often overflowing the constraints imposed by those small, cold and static numbers that only tell one part of the story... and then suddenly we have governments that believe that their main job is to optimize mostly for efficiency and productivity: the city as machine, progress as GDP, graphs instead of life.

But some of the most important urban dynamics happen in the (uncountable) gaps between things: between people, deep in symbolic territory, within language and metaphor, inside the folds of the city: in the diverse ways communities create multiple forms of belonging to each other and to their surroundings; in the way we silently and subjectively make sense, make meaning, make — indeed — city.

This is the reason I am so interested in transdisciplinary practices and participatory processes that take into account multiple sources of knowledge(s) and expertise.

I am the former head of Laboratorio para la Ciudad and Chief Creative Officer for Mexico City, and founder of Experimentalista[1]. I am so interested in a closer relationship between the urban sciences and the humanities, plus a much deeper understanding of urban culture. Urban culture as a deep social code.

Hence, Experimentalista — the urban+creative studio I founded a little less than a year ago, soon after I left government — is a space where urban and political scientists work closely with artists, philosophers and other disciplines related to the humanities. We gather communities around questions, driven by exploration, curiosity and a relentless belief in our collective capacity to create more imaginative realities for all. For us narrative strategies are just

1
http://www.experimentalistas.com

as important as hard data; human rights are entangled with aesthetics; our subjective lives and personal beliefs are as much an area of inquiry as their objective social manifestations.

We also know experimentation is only the beginning. Ideas must take on a life of their own. Drawing from several fields and methodologies, we focus on what is needed to create deep culture shifts at different scales and depths — from a megalopolis, to a single block or company; from foundational research to experimentation on the ground; from quick, concentrated skill-building to long-term project implementation. And every detail is tailor-made for the project at hand: teams, governance structure and beyond.

So answering Katherine's question, from this perspective, first of all urban diversity has to be treated as one of the city's greatest assets, instead of simply as a hurdle to overcome... diversity and inclusion as "the right thing to do", yes, but also for the sake of sheer social ingenuity and possibility. Because the more ideas we can tap into, the more access a city has to different skills, talents and even world views: the more creative capacity a society will have, prompting a more active and ample metabolism feeding urban life at its most expansive.

That said, diversity in its truest form seems to be the Achilles' heel of many a progressive society. Places such as Denmark, Finland, Switzerland, with a solid understanding of the importance of the public, the commons, the collective, fall short on issues like migration. (Denmark, for example, a paragon of social democracy on many fronts, shockingly has recently declared a policy of "Zero Asylum")[2].

Some of my favorite participatory experiments as founder of Laboratorio para la Ciudad were also some of the most complex. A place like Mexico City is a territory composed both of collaboration and contestation. And its magnificent diversity can also, unfortunately, be translated into divisiveness and inequality.

But with projects such as crowdsourcing the Mexico City Constitution[3] or city-wide debates around contested subjects, we realized that what we do have in common is the city and its future. And that we will never get rid of the tensions — the hope should be to make those tensions as productive as possible.

To this end, urban projects need participatory scaffolding — and ideally permanent civic infrastructure — that is just as nuanced and multiple as the city itself. Our views of what (for example) co-creation means or (over-simplified) processes such as design thinking need to evolve. We need participation that leaves political theater behind, and instead thinks deeply about why and how participation creates public value. This has to do with generating new contexts for emerging knowledge and transdisciplinary practices; it also has to take into account the different types of knowledge in a society. There needs to be a place both for talented academics and for concerned neighbors; for youngsters and the elderly; for people of all walks of life. This starts our journey towards true urban governance — hybrid, dynamic, multiple. And all of this needs to travel the different scales of the city: from the *barrio* level to the entire megalopolis.

In this paradigm, I believe the role of government is also to orchestrate the different talents of a city.

It also has to take into account that democracy is not meant to function outside of social tensions, but within them. We cannot be naive. We need to design this participatory scaffolding with enough

2 https://www.theguardian.com/global-development/2022/may/25/zero-asylum-seekers-denmark-forces-refugees-to-return-to-syria#:~:text=Blinkenberg%20says%20Denmark's%20policy%20towards,wanted%20'zero%20asylum%20seekers'.

3 https://citiesofservice.jhu.edu/resource/crowdsourcing-a-constitution-mexico-city/

diid No. 77 — 2022
Doi: 10.30682/diid7722e

layers to allow us to work through these tensions, taking into account that yes, the tyranny of the majority exists, that there are people out there who would wish for fewer social rights (abortion, gay marriage, euthanasia) instead of more. That the "not in my back yard" phenomenon is all too common and even basic notions of democracy writ large are living through a crisis across the world at this moment. So we need to dive into new meanings for civics, we need to rethink education, we need a new model of urban pedagogy that will allow for our voices and our decisions to mature, for us to discuss more deeply, to create more public value, both individually and collectively...

It has been said that most of the ills of the world stem from an imagination gone stagnant. (Indeed, my own personal leitmotif for decades now and in different roles - including government — has been "imagination is not a luxury"[4]).

The erosion of democracy we are living through makes a good case for the need to be bold, to experiment and expand opportunities for participation in collective life. But "culture" and "imagination" still seem to be odd bedfellows when thinking about urban policy. What is the place of urban culture writ large in the creation of a radical societal vision? Beyond numbers and technocratic arguments, how do we bring new possibilities to life to answer the question of "what a city is for"? And how do we anchor the right to the city in daily life, democratize the right to imagine? What has Bologna learned from its political past and how is that being actualized today in concepts such as civic imagination? What is your hope for the politics of tomorrow, in other words?

4
https://blog.ted.com/imagination-is-not-a-luxury-fellows-friday-with-gabriella-gomez-mont/

Raffaele Laudani and Giovanni Ginocchini — Italy

My name is Raffaele Laudani and I am Deputy Mayor for Urban Planning, Universities and Research Centers, special projects *City of Knowledge* and *Democratic Memory*. And my name is Giovanni Ginocchini, Manager for Public Spaces and the *Green Handprint* project at the Municipality of Bologna. In 2018 we founded the Foundation for Urban Innovation with strong support from the Municipality and the University of Bologna, to design an institution with unprecedented features that constantly redefines boundaries, moving transversely to produce ideas and solutions that can respond, through its open model, to the transformative processes of the city.

Bologna has a long history as a place of openness that enables democratic dialogue, and at the same time is characterized by a strong communitarian orientation (so deeply rooted that it risks being exclusive and conservative in some areas).

These characteristics of the city were also reinforced by a series of events that in the second half of the 20th century marked the city's identity and memory: the Italian Resistance, the 1977 student movements, the Ustica air disaster and the August 2nd bombing at the Bologna train station, to mention just a few.

Over time, Bologna has strengthened its role as a University city and centre of knowledge, with almost one hundred thousand students and numerous research infrastructures, in part related to studies of the events that characterised the city and its democratic perspective.

The pandemic has reasserted the centrality of knowledge and culture in the processes of innovation and the response to the global

challenges of our time (Subirats, 2018), as well as in supporting the daily life of people at local level, which is constantly evolving, shifting between the individual and collective dimensions of the right to the city[5].

Science, research and knowledge are a fundamental resource, not only to emerge from the crisis we are experiencing, but also to imagine new lines of development and a new centrality for cities, which are required to deal with local issues while maintaining the ability to position themselves within the European and international context of sustainable growth and multi-level innovation.

City of Knowledge is the Bologna framework that holds together the democratic cultural dimension and the processes of urban transformation, through co-design, urban planning and cultural and scientific leverage.

The transition processes (fair, ecological and digital as requested by the European Green Deal) could only be activated and retained over time by beginning with a practice of listening that involves the people of the city (including the more vulnerable categories), tracking their real needs and defining alliances interested and capable of providing answers, then jointly imagining the vocations of places and new services. In our experience, this collective imagination can guide the transformative processes in Bologna through strategies and practices characterised as much as possible by co-design, open innovation and social justice.

Some instruments and structures have already been established and designed by the city as "knowledge and cultural actions", such as the Urban Innovation Foundation, which is the Living Lab instituted by the Municipality and the University (a fine example of new alliances that can support the process) and the Regulation for the care and regeneration of the urban Commons (Iaione, 2013) as an institutional regulatory device (currently under revision). Others are being developed and tested: the creation in the start-up phase of the city's *Digital Twin* (which will be built through the civic use of data) and the *Polo della Memoria Democratica* project. Because there is no future without memory.

With the New European Bauhaus, Europe is also urging us for the first time to look together at the dimensions of sustainability, inclusion, and finally the aesthetic dimension of urban design. How can we activate and support this multidisciplinary approach to the transformation of the city? What is the role of co-design processes in this challenge? How can we involve and assign a role to all the subjects that make up the urban ecosystem?

5 https://www.fondazioneinnovazioneurbana.it/images/2020_10_14_Bolognariparte/BOLOGNA_RIPARTE_Oltre_lemergenza_Coronavirus.pdf

Ambra Trotto — Sweden

My name is Ambra Trotto and I am an Associate Professor at the Umeå Institute of Design, as well as senior researcher at the RISE Research Institutes of Sweden. My main assignment is as the Design and Research Director of d.centre, a European endeavour that catalyses ecosystems to transform existing practices into sustainable ones, through design, by initiating and curating multidimensional and transdisciplinary synergies based on beauty, diversity and meaning, to realise sustainable futures.

diid No. 77 — 2022
Doi: 10.30682/diid7722e

A tremendous window of opportunity has now opened in Europe. Enormous attention is paid by institutions to culture and creativity, in the conviction that they can foster a paradigm shift towards a sustainable way of being and acting in the world.

All of a sudden, the products of creative processes are being noticed across society and there is hope that they might be key in transforming current processes into sustainable ones. This raises a new challenge, which lies in learning to integrate design processes that are endowed with imaginative power, lateral thinking and aesthetic qualities, into existing processes. These existing processes are a product of industrial mechanisms that reward efficiency, strive for optimisation and standardisation and take problematic notions, such as growth, for granted.

The challenge of working with design for systemic transformation is to elaborate methods, approaches, skills and techniques, so that design can become an effective wedge to transform all sectors in society (Daram Westling & Byström, 2022). To transform how such sectors work within and across their zones. Artistic, creative and cultural expressions have tremendous power and a significant role in our society. However, the gap between them and, for instance, industrial contexts or policy-making spaces is yet to be filled. Such expressions can be injected in all sectors, through design processes, in an acupunctural process that discloses new opportunities, driven by a life-centred sensitivity.

One relevant aspect that our discipline can tackle, is the ability to better understand and describe transformation, when it occurs. Transformation, in a complex, transdisciplinary, trans-sectorial situation is rarely linear; causal relationships, in which the occurrence of one event is the cause of another, cannot be the only way to observe and predict transformation. In delving into the phenomenology of transformation, there is an opportunity to learn what kind of relationships to observe and intervene on, in order to both predict and contribute to a transformation. Unpacking the notion of impact, or rather the notion of wicked impact (Peeters et al., 2017), will provide us with awareness and tools for directing how we want to transform our practices in the direction of sustainability (Trotto et al., 2022).

In this endeavour regarding designing for societal transformation, a prominent topic to consider is aesthetics. From a design perspective, we are concerned with aesthetics and how we give form to things (as participatory design things, according to the connotation expressed by Binder et al. (2011)). One of the dilemmas in working with complexity relates to the tension between aesthetics and democratic, participatory processes, when designing for sustainable societal transformation.

The synthetic operation of form-giving differentiates design as a discipline from other processes that work with participation. The moment of synthesis is necessarily a decision-making moment by some, in opposition to others, where aesthetics and consensus struggle to coexist. Participation could support the integration of the aesthetic dimension into the creative and sustainable transformation of society, to define new processes and new elements that can increase people's sense of belonging and engagement in the transformative processes.

Katherine Mollenhauer Gajardo
She is a Professor at the School of Design at the Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile. Her work focuses on Design Policies, Design-driven innovation, Service Design for the Public. She is also a researcher in the Nucleus on Governance and Territorial Planning Sectors (NuGOT), the Public Innovation Lab and the Service Design Group.

Gabriella Gómez-Mont
She is Founder and CEO of Experimentalista, a novel type of nomadic and creative office specialised in cities — which constantly shifts shape to accommodate high-level, transdisciplinary collaborations across the world. She was also the Chief Creative Officer of Mexico City, and the founder of Laboratorio para la Ciudad (2013-2018), the award-winning experimental arm and creative think-tank of the Mexico City government, reporting to the Mayor.

Raffaelle Laudani
Deputy Mayor for Urban Planning, Universities and Research Centres, special projects City of Knowledge and Democratic Memory. He is a Full Professor of the History of Political Doctrines at the University of Bologna. He has taught at Columbia University in New York and was the coordinator of the Doctorate in the Global history, cultures and politics. He heads the Academy of Global Humanities and Critical Theory, the Master's Degree in Management and co-production of participatory processes, communities and networks of proximity.

Giovanni Ginocchini
Manager for Public Spaces and the Green Handprint project at the Municipality of Bologna. He is an architect and director since 2018 of the Fondazione per l'Innovazione Urbana in Bologna, and since 2012 of the Urban Centre of the Municipality of Bologna. He was the Coordinator of the Istituto di Ricerca Sociale in Milan from 2011 to 2012.

Conclusion

All these reflections are strongly linked to the direct experiences of the authors and their geographies of action. They trigger further queries concerning the need to design collaborative transformations through adaptive and inclusive processes of constant negotiation, between institutions and civic society, top-down policies and bottom-up practices, innovation and tradition, openness and protection of endemic specificities, global perspective and local answers. In order to be sustainable, these transformations must involve the entire flow of design and action, integrating actors and resources, including unconventional and submerged ones, and constantly updating the dimensions of the intervention: from the micro to the macro scale, from the individual to society, from the real to the digital environments. The common goal is to match cultural and economic growth, education and training, to support sustainable and fair opportunities for all, stimulating interrelated actions to connect existing places to new human activities (catalysed by associations, institutions, bottom-up movements) that can leverage site-specific cultural, social, economic and environmental values.

Ambra Trotto
She is an Associate Professor at the Umeå Institute of Design, at Umeå University and a senior researcher at the RISE Research Institute of Sweden, where she leads the area of Design for Societal Transformation and she is senior advisor for the Digital Ethics Initiative. She is also a guest researcher at the Eindhoven University of Technology, where she collaborates with the chair of Systemic Change.

diid No. 77 — 2022
Doi: 10.30682/diid7722e

References

Aguirre, M. (2020). *Transforming Public Organizations into Co-Designing Cultures: A Study of Capacity-Building Programs as Learning Ecosystems* [Unpublished doctoral dissertation]. Oslo School of Architecture and Design.

Binder, T., De Michelis, G., Ehn, P., Jacucci, G., & Linde, P. (2011). *Design Things*. MIT Press. doi: https://doi.org/10.7551/mitpress/8262.001.0001

CoLab. (2016). Follow the Rabbit: A Field Guide to Systemic Design. https://drive.google.com/file/d/0B0KwcwVigAntYm00Tzl4WnZTX0k/view?resourcekey=0-JLitBtyV4O8BW86milC2Jg

Daram Westling, L., & Byström, D. (2022). *Design as a force for development. A study on ways of thinking and working for society's transformation towards sustainability.* Svensk Form.

Godet, M. (2000). *La caja de herramientas de la prospectiva estratégica.* Cuaderno n. 5, Gerpa. http://es.laprospective.fr/dyn/espagnol/bo-lips-esp.pdf

Iaione C. (2013). La città come bene comune. *Aedon*, 1. http://www.aedon.mulino.it/archivio/2013/1/iaione.htm

LIP - Laboratorio de Innovación Pública (2017). *Co-producción con el usuario en los servicios públicos.* Documento de trabajo nº1, Pontificia Universidad Católica. https://static1.squarespace.com/static/61b25f2b8484122ce915c901/t/622f6a4cbfd060137e7fc7b7/1647274572596/2017+LIP_La-co-produccion_del_usuario_en_los_servicios_publicos_DT1.pdf

Manzini, E. (2009). Service design in the age of networks. In S. Miettinen, & M. Koivisto (Eds.), *Designing services with innovative methods*. University of Art and Design Helsinki.

Mulgan, G. (2014). *Innovation in the Public Sector: How Can Public Organisations Better Create, Improve and Adapt?*. Nesta. https://media.nesta.org.uk/documents/innovation_in_the_public_sector-_how_can_public_organisations_better_create_improve_and_adapt_0.pdf

Orellana Ossandón, A., Arenas Vásquez, F., & Moreno Alba, D. (2020). Ordenamiento territorial en Chile: Nuevo escenario para la gobernanza regional. *Revista de geografía Norte Grande*, 77, 31-49. https://doi.org/10.4067/S0718-34022020000300031

Parés Franzi, M., Ospina, S., & Subirats, J. (2017). *Social Innovation and Democratic Leadership: Communities and Social Change from Below*. Edward Elgar Publishing.

Peeters, J., Papworth, N., Glaser, P., Collevecchio, C., Betancour, A., & Trotto, A. (2017). No Man is an Island. Situated Design Research and Wicked Impact. *The Design Journal*, *20*(1), S3354-S3367. http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/14606925.2017.1352840

Pinazo-Dallenbach, P., & Tutistar-Rosero, D. (2020). Evaluación de procesos de planificación y gestión territorial, un aporte metodológico desde una revisión de enfoques. *Cuadernos de geografía*, 104, 29-86.

Pujadas, R., & Font, J. (1998). *Ordenación y planificación territorial*. Colección Espacios y Sociedades, Serie Mayor. Editorial Síntesis.

Ryan, A. (2013). A theory of systemic design. *Proceedings of Relating Systems Thinking and Design (RSD2) 2013 Symposium.* Oslo, Norway, October 9-11, 2013. https://drive.google.com/file/d/1yVyTCdu3mvngXCpGui64oQrwXiTASGCx/view

Ryan, A. (2014). A Framework for Systemic Design. *FormAkademisk*, 7(4), 1-14. https://doi.org/10.7577/formakademisk.787

Sanders, E. B.-N., & Stappers, P. J. (2008). Co-creation and the new landscapes of design. *CoDesign*, *4*(1), 5-18. https://doi.org/10.1080/15710880701875068

Sanders, L., & Simons, G. (2009). A Social Vision for Value Co-creation in Design. *Open Source Business Resource*. http://timreview.ca/article/310

Sevaldson, B. (2016). *SOD is open source*. https://www.systemsorientetteddesign.net/index.php/sod/sod-is-open-source

Sevaldson, B. (2019). What is Systemic Design? Practices Beyond Analyses and Modelling. *Proceedings of Relating Systems Thinking and Design (RSD8) 2019 Symposium*. IIT Institute of Design, Chicago, October 13-15, 2019.

Sevaldson, B., & Jones, P. (2019). An Interdiscipline Emerges: Pathways to Systemic Design. *She Ji: The Journal of Design, Economics, and Innovation*, *5*(2), 75-84. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sheji.2019.05.002

Trotto, A., Hummels, C. C. M., Levy, P. D., Peeters, J. P. A., van der Veen, R., Yoo, D., Johansson, M., Johansson, M., Smith, M. L., & van der Zwan, S. (2021). *Designing for Transforming Practices: Maps and Journeys*. Technische Universiteit Eindhoven.

diid No. 77 — 2022
Doi: 10.30682/diid7722e